

Handout: David Hume - *An Enquiry Concerning Human Understanding*, Section VII: “Of the Idea of Necessary Connexion”

I. The Problem and the Proposed Solution

The Problem:

Hume confronts a central metaphysical and epistemological question of early modern philosophy:

What is our idea of *necessary connection*—the “power,” “force,” or “energy” by which causes produce their effects?

Philosophers routinely speak of *causes* as if they contain some **necessary tie** to their effects. When one billiard ball strikes another, we say the first *causes* the motion of the second. But what do we mean by this necessity? Do we perceive it? Are we conscious of it? Can we form a clear idea of it?

Hume’s challenge begins with language:

- We use the language of **power**, **energy**, and **necessary connection** constantly.
- Yet these terms may be **obscure or even meaningless** if they cannot be traced back to some impression (i.e. a sensation or something we reflect on).

The Solution (Hume’s Thesis):

The idea of necessary connection does not arise from perceiving any power in objects, nor from any inner awareness of causal force in ourselves.

Rather, it arises from a *feeling in the mind*: the **customary transition of the imagination** from cause to effect after repeated experience of their constant conjunction.

Necessity is not “in the objects.” It is projected by the mind.

II. Background: The Debate Hume Is Entering

To understand the radicality of Hume's argument, students need context.

1. Early Modern Causation

Philosophers before Hume largely assumed:

- **Aristotle:** Causes involve real powers or natures.
- **Descartes:** God conserves motion; bodies interact through contact.
- **Locke:** We derive the idea of power from observing change (and perhaps from our own volition).
- **Malebranche (Occasionalism):** Created things have no real causal power—God is the only true cause.
- **Scholastics:** Spoke of substantial forms and real powers in nature.

All sides assumed that *there is* some real metaphysical tie between cause and effect.

Hume asks:

What is the origin of our idea of that tie?

2. Hume's Copy Principle

From Section II (invoked here at §4):

All ideas are copies of prior impressions.

- *Impressions* = vivid sensory or introspective experiences.
- *Ideas* = faint copies of impressions.

If we cannot locate the **impression** corresponding to an idea, then the idea is suspect.

Thus Hume's methodological strategy:

To clarify the idea of necessary connection, find the impression from which it is derived (§5).

III. Structure of the Argument (Mirroring the Text)

A. The Obscurity of Metaphysical Terms (§§1–3)

Hume begins with a methodological reflection:

- Mathematics has clear, determinate ideas.
- Moral and metaphysical philosophy suffers from obscurity.
- Terms like **power**, **force**, **energy**, **necessary connexion** are especially unclear (§3).

Hence the task:

Fix the precise meaning of these terms.

B. Search for the Impression of Necessary Connection

Hume conducts a systematic search.

IV. First Attempt: External Objects (§§6–8)

Observation:

When we observe causation in the world:

- One billiard ball strikes another.
- Flame is followed by heat.
- Events follow one another in succession.

But what do we perceive?

We perceive only **one event following another** (§6).

We never perceive:

- A necessary tie.
- A power binding them.
- An intelligible force.

Crucial claim:

In a single instance of causation, nothing suggests necessary connection (§6).

Even after careful scrutiny:

- All we observe is **succession** and **contiguity**.
- The “force” is entirely concealed (§8).

Therefore:

The idea of power cannot be derived from external observation.

V. Second Attempt: Internal Volition (§§9–20)

A natural objection:

Perhaps we are conscious of power when we will our limbs to move.

Hume examines three possibilities:

A. Volition and Bodily Motion (§§9–15)

We seem aware that:

- Our will causes our arm to rise.

But Hume argues:

1. We do not understand the mechanism (§10–14).
2. We do not know why the will affects some organs but not others (§12).
3. Paralysis cases show we are not conscious of genuine power (§13).
4. The physiological chain is hidden (§14).

Conclusion:

We learn the connection only through experience, not through consciousness of power (§15).

B. Volition and Ideas (§§16–20)

Perhaps we are aware of power when we call ideas to mind.

Hume replies:

- We are not acquainted with the nature of the soul or its causal aptitude (§17).
- Our control over thought varies (§18–19).
- We do not experience any “creative energy” (§20).

Conclusion:

Even internal mental causation provides no impression of necessary connection.

VI. Interlude: Occasionalism (§§21–25)

Hume now addresses theologians and philosophers who argue:

- Since we cannot understand physical causation,
- God must be the immediate cause of every event.

This is **Occasionalism** (Malebranche).

Hume's critique:

- We are equally ignorant of divine causation (§25).
- Ignorance does not justify positing divine intervention.
- The theory exceeds the limits of human understanding (§24).

Key skeptical move:

If our ignorance of natural power disqualifies it, then our ignorance of divine power disqualifies that as well.

VII. The Pivotal Turn: Constant Conjunction and Custom (§§26–28)

Having eliminated all candidate impressions, Hume seems ready for a skeptical conclusion:

Perhaps “necessary connection” is meaningless (§26).

But he identifies a new source:

When:

- One type of event has been constantly conjoined with another,
- And we repeatedly observe this pattern,

Then:

The mind forms a habit of expecting the second upon seeing the first (§28).

The crucial move:

The necessary connection is not in the objects—but in the mind.

Specifically:

- After repeated conjunctions,
- The imagination transitions automatically from cause to effect.

This felt transition is:

The impression from which the idea of necessity is copied (§28).

VIII. Hume's Definitions of Cause (§29)

Hume offers two definitions:

1. **Constant Conjunction Definition**

A cause is an object followed by another, where all similar objects are followed by similar objects.

2. **Psychological Definition**

A cause is an object whose appearance conveys the thought to its usual effect.

These definitions are “extraneous” (§29):

- They do not capture some metaphysical principle.
 - They describe observable regularity and psychological inference.
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IX. Recapitulation (§30)

Hume summarizes:

- Every idea must derive from an impression.
- No single instance of causation yields an impression of power.
- Repeated instances produce a new impression: habitual expectation.
- This feeling is the origin of the idea of necessity.

Thus:

Necessary connection is a projection of the mind grounded in custom.

Dictionary

Impression

Hume's meaning: A vivid, forceful perception.

In human terms: A direct experience — something you feel, see, hear, or undergo right now.

Examples:

- The sensation of heat
- The feeling of anger
- The experience of willing your arm to move

Impressions are the *raw data* of the mind.

Idea

Hume's meaning: A faint copy of an impression.

In human terms: A memory, thought, or mental image of something previously experienced.

Seeing fire = impression

Remembering fire = idea

All ideas must ultimately come from impressions (the **Copy Principle**).

Necessary Connection

Hume's meaning: The supposed binding force that makes an effect follow from a cause.

In human terms: The “must-ness” we think exists between cause and effect.

When we say, “Fire *must* produce heat,” we think there’s some invisible glue connecting them. Hume argues this glue is not observed in the world but arises from habit in the mind.

Power / Force / Energy

Hume treats these as roughly synonymous.

In human terms:

The supposed inner capacity of a cause to produce its effect.

When philosophers say a cause “has the power” to produce an effect, they assume there is something in the object that guarantees the result.

Hume’s question:

Where do we get the idea of this “power”?

Constant Conjunction

Hume’s meaning: Repeated pairing of similar types of events.

In human terms: Two things always showing up together.

Example:

- Every time we observe flame, we observe heat.
- Every time billiard ball A strikes B, B moves.

This repetition is crucial to Hume’s theory of causation.

Custom / Habit

One of Hume’s most important concepts.

In human terms:

The mind’s automatic tendency to expect one event after repeatedly seeing it follow another.

After enough repetitions, your brain just anticipates what comes next. You don’t reason it out — it happens naturally.

For Hume, habit is:

The true source of our idea of necessary connection.

Determination of the Mind

In human terms:

The feeling of being mentally pushed from one thought to another.

After repeated experience, when you see the cause, your mind is “carried” to the effect. That internal push is what we mistakenly project onto the world as “necessity.”

Transition of the Imagination

Closely related to habit.

In human terms:

The mind’s smooth movement from the idea of the cause to the idea of the effect.

This transition feels compelling — and that feeling becomes the idea of necessity.

Single Instance

In human terms:

One isolated case of something happening.

Hume emphasizes:

In one single case of A followed by B, we never perceive necessity.

You only see succession.

Contiguity

In human terms:

Closeness in space or time.

Causes and effects are typically near each other. But proximity is not necessity.

Volition

In human terms:

An act of willing — deciding to do something.

Hume examines whether we get the idea of power from willing our limbs to move. His answer: no.

Occasionalism

A background theological theory (Malebranche).

In human terms:

The view that God directly causes every event.

According to occasionalists:

- Fire does not cause heat.
- God causes heat when fire appears.

Hume argues this doesn't solve the problem, because we are just as ignorant of divine power as of natural power.

Experience

For Hume, this does not mean “rational insight.”

In human terms:

Repeated observation of patterns.

Experience teaches us:

- What regularly follows what.
- Not why.

Cause (Hume's Two Definitions)

Hume gives two definitions:

1. Regularity Definition

A cause is:

An object followed by another, where all similar objects are followed by similar objects.

In human terms:

A cause is just something that is reliably followed by something else.

2. Psychological Definition

A cause is:

An object whose appearance always conveys the thought to another.

In human terms:

A cause is something that makes us automatically think of its effect.

Union of Soul and Body

Early modern problem:

How can a non-material mind move a material body?

Hume's point:

We are no less ignorant here than in physical causation.
